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Unknowing the future: Speculative foresight in international institutions and the unexpected 'origins' of expertise

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Abstract

Amidst a deepening sense of uncertainty and polycrisis, how do international organizations (IOs) relate to the future? This article explores the politics of speculative foresight as a pervasive but sparsely researched and undertheorized form of future-oriented expertise in international institutions that taps into eclectic knowledge genres – such as art and literature, management philosophy, geopolitics, and esotericism. First, I examine how foresight is created and validated as a bundle of epistemic practice in contemporary IOs. As a way of knowing, I find that foresight is authorized through claims to innovation, imagination, pluralism, and methodological correctness, challenging established understandings of IO expertise as based on bureaucratic rationality and scientific objectivity. Moreover, I argue that foresight differs from more well-researched future-oriented practices, like risk technologies, forecasting, and anticipatory modeling, by imagining the future as contingent, plural, and unknowable. In a second genealogical move, I illustrate how this specific rendering of the future was made possible historically through the establishment of futures studies as an activist, utopian, and aesthetic counter-project to 'scientific' Cold War futurology. The article mobilizes performative thinking in social theory and STS and builds on a transversal analysis of IO documents, digital platforms and archives, futurist writings, and historical literature.

Keywords: epistemic practices; foresight; futures; genealogy; international organizations; uncertainty

Introduction

In a time of resurging geopolitical rivalry and large-scale military conflict, looming climate disaster, technological disruptions, and pandemics, the future of global politics is routinely painted as radically uncertain in both academic discussions and global policy discourse (for recent examples, see[1]). Amidst this heightened sense of flux and polycrisis, political organizations on the world stage are re-evaluating how they think and act in relation to the future. Beyond well-researched forms of anticipatory expertise that seeks to render future uncertainties manageable through probability and approximation, speculative foresight that posits the future as radically *un*knowable and enables organizations to imagine *multiple possible* futures[2] is gaining traction across regional and

[1]Peter J. Katzenstein, *Uncertainty and Its Discontents: Worldviews in World Politics* (Cambridge University Press, 2022); Anastasia Shesterinina and Miriam Matejova, *Uncertainty in Global Politics* (London: Routledge, 2024); Brett Ashley Leeds, Layna Mosley, B. Peter Rosendorff and Ayşe Zarakol, 'The future of global governance and world order', *International Organization*, 79 (2025), pp. S1–S11.

[2]Sohail Inayatullah, 'Futures studies: Theories and methods', in Nayef Al-Fodhan, *There's a Future: Visions for a Better World* (BBVA, 2013), pp. 36–66.

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multilateral international organizations[3] (IOs). For instance, as the COVID-19 pandemic swept the globe in 2020, the World Health Organization (WHO) established a brand new unit dedicated to global health foresight.[4] Two years later, the organizations' first ever foresight report used scenario planning to explore 'what the future of infectious threats might look like', inviting its readers to 'imagine the different directions that the current and future pandemics might take and to expand the range of plausible futures'.[5] With this recent investment in futures thinking, the WHO is not alone: across global policy domains such as international peace and security,[6] sustainable development,[7] and economic[8] and regional cooperation,[9] foresight is perceived as an essential toolkit for IOs as they seek to navigate contemporary uncertainties, preparing for unknown future threats and possibilities.

This article addresses a significant research gap on the politics of foresight as a pervasive,[10] but scarcely researched and undertheorized form of expertise in contemporary international institutions. Existing scholarship on foresight is sparse in IR, political science, and the broader study of global politics. Much of it focuses on the supposed promises of foresight as a potential methodology to be employed in academic research.[11] This article, by contrast, approaches foresight from a sociology of knowledge perspective; it explores foresight as a specific form of future-oriented expertise in IOs and aims to throw light on i) its contemporary operation as a bundle of epistemic practices and ii) its contingent historical emergence. Theoretically, I mobilize Karin Knorr Cetina's notions of epistemic practices,[12] and I build on performative accounts of the future in social theory[13] and science and technology studies[14] (STS). Empirically, my account is based on a transversal analysis of IO policy documents, digital platforms and historical archives, futurist writings, and secondary literature on the history of futurisms.

I proceed in two main steps. First, I examine foresight expertise as a bundle of epistemic practices in contemporary IOs. Specifically, I attend to how foresight is created and validated as expertise across organizations, and I analyze how it constitutes the future as a temporal register that IOs and other political actors can relate to and seek to manipulate. Based on this account, I argue that foresight differs from other future-oriented practices that are better understood and more well-researched, such as risk technologies, forecasting, and predictive and anticipatory modeling. While the latter seek to control and mitigate future uncertainties through probability and predictive approximation, foresight constitutes the future as plural, radically indeterminate, and

[3]Monika Sus and Marcel Hadeed, 'Theory-infused and policy-relevant: On the usefulness of scenario analysis for international relations', *Contemporary Security Policy*, 41 (2020), pp. 432–455.

[4]WHO, 'Science Division: Harnessing the power of science to achieve health for all' (World Health Organization, 2024).

[5]WHO, *Imagining the Future of Pandemics and Epidemics* (World Health Organization, 2022).

[6]NATO, 'Allied Command Transformation: Strategic Foresight Analysis 2023' (NATO, 2023).

[7]UNDP, 'Foresight Manual: Empowered Futures for the 2030 Agenda' (United Nations Development Programme, 2018).

[8]OECD, 'Strategic Foresight at the OECD' (OECD, 2024).

[9]AU, *The Africa Governance Report 2021: Africa's Governance Furtures for the Africa we Want* (African Union, 2021); EC, *2023 Strategic Foresight Report, European Commission* (COM [2023] 376 final, 2023).

[10]ISC, 'A Guide to Anticipation: Working Paper on Tools and Methods of Horizon Scanning and Foresight' (International Science Council, 2024).

[11]Iver B. Neumann and Erik F. Øverland, 'International relations and policy planning: The method of perspectivist scenario building', *International Studies Perspectives*, 5 (2004), pp. 258–277; Steven Bernstein, Richard Lebow, Janice Gross Stein, and Steven Weber, 'God Gave Physics the Easy Problems: Adapting Social Science to an Unpredictable World', *European Journal of International Relations*, 6 (2000), pp. 43–76.

[12]Karin Knorr Cetina, *Epistemic Cultures: How the Sciences Make Knowledge* (Cambridge, Massachusetts: Harvard University Press, 1999); Karin Knorr Cetina, 'Sociality with objects: Social relations in postsocial knowledge societies', *Theory, Culture and Society*, 14 (1997), pp. 1–30.

[13]Richard Tutton, 'Wicked futures: Meaning, matter and the sociology of the future', *The Sociological Review*, 65 (2017), pp. 478–492; Jeroen Oomen, Jeroen Hoffman, and Maarten A. Hajer, 'Techniques of futuring: On how imagined futures become socially performative', *European Journal of Social Theory*, 25 (2022), pp. 252–270.

[14]Sheila Jasanoff, 'Future imperfect: Science, technology, and the imaginations of modernity', in S. Jasanoff and S. H. Kim (eds), *Dreamscapes of Modernity: Sociotechnical Imaginaries and the Fabrication of Power* (University of Chicago Press, 2015); Sheila Jasanoff, *The Ethics of Invention: Technology and the Human Future* (W. W. Norton, 2016).

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beyond the grasp of present knowledge – thus allowing for organizations to relate to future threats and possibilities amidst contingency and flux. Moreover, I find that foresight is authorized through claims to innovation and imagination, transdisciplinary eclecticism, pluralism, and methodological correctness in ways that challenge established notions of IO expertise as based on bureaucratic rationalities, scientific objectivity, and political neutrality.

In a second move, I illustrate how the specific rendering of the future as plural and contingent that undergirds IO foresight in the present emerged in the second half of the 20th century. Through a genealogical exploration of historical archives and scholarly writings, I find that foresight has a complex history that includes both genres, people, and places that are not usually associated with either IOs or with authoritative expertise more broadly speaking – such as science fiction literature and the fine arts, management philosophy, geopolitical strategy, utopianism, and spiritual traditions. More specifically, I show that the onto-epistemic commitments that permeate IO foresight practices in the present were made possible through the establishment of 'futures studies' as an activist, utopian, and aesthetic counter-project to how mainstream Cold War futurology that had been envisioned as a science of forecasting and prediction and a vital toolbox in strategic competition. While foresight is presently promoted as a new and innovative set of tools for IOs and other global governance actors to cultivate, my historical account throws a critical light on such claims to novelty by illustrating that scholars of world politics and IOs themselves were, in fact, deeply involved in the historical emergence of foresight during the Cold War.

In the next two sections of this article, I situate my account in the literature before elaborating on my theoretical points of departure and conceptual contribution. In the following section, I examine foresight as a bundle of epistemic practices in contemporary IOs. Thereafter, I explore the genealogy of foresight in the second half of the 20th century. Finally, I conclude by offering some reflections on the article's main findings and by sketching paths for further research.

Knowledge and future(s) in international organizations

Across IR, political science, and neighbouring disciplines, the usage of speculative foresight in international institutions is poorly studied as an empirical phenomenon and present political practice. In fact, most existing studies on foresight have reacted to the recent popularity of these techniques in policy circles by suggesting how they may enrich political science and IR as a research methodology.[15] Some of these contributions provide valuable snapshots of the growing interest in foresight outside of academia.[16] However, in-depth empirical studies and critical analyses of how IOs and other political organizations engage in foresight as a form of expertise are lacking. This article therefore addresses a significant empirical research gap. Conceptually, the article situates itself at the crossroads of two broader literatures: the study of how imagined futures affect political practices and scholarship on IO expertise. I will address both of these research strands below.

Historically, research on international politics has engaged with the future in long-standing debates on the dangers and virtues of utopianism in world affairs;[17] theorized the effects of expectations and psychological perceptions of the future in strategic interactions amongst policymakers;[18]

[15]Neumann and Øverland, 'International Relations and Policy Planning', pp. 258-277; Sus and Hadeed, 'Theory-infused and policy-relevant', pp. 432-455; Fomin et al 2021; Miller 2022.

[16]Sus and Hadeed, 'Theory-infused and policy-relevant', pp. 432-455.

[17]Edward Hallett Carr, *The Twenty Years' Crisis 1919–1939: An Introduction to the Study of International Relations* (Macmillan & Co, 1946); William A. Callahan, 'Remembering the future – Utopia, empire, and harmony in 21st-century international theory', *European Journal of International Relations*, 10 (2004), pp. 569–601; John H. Herz, *The Nation-State and the Crisis of World Politics: Essays on International Politics in the Twentieth Century* (McKay, 1976)

[18]Thierry Balzacq and Robert Jervis, 'Logics of mind and international system: A journey with Robert Jervis', *Review of International Studies*, 30 (2004), pp. 559–582; Robert Jervis, *Perception and Misperception in International Politics* (Princeton University Press, 1976); Janice Gross Stein, 'Psychological explanations of international conflict', in Walter Carlsnaes, Thomas Risse, and Beth A. Simmons (eds), *Handbook of International Relations* (Sage, 2003).

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and pondered the question of whether IR can be predictive in a natural science-sense of the term.[19] More recent literature has drawn on existentialist philosophy and psychoanalysis (amongst other sources of inspiration) in theorizing the future as a source of existential anxiety that operates as a productive force in identity construction[20] and inspires ontological security narratives, routines, and actions aimed at stabilizing a state's sense of self.[21] Finally, the concept of the future has, naturally, featured prominently in IR's 'temporal turn',[22] be it in the context of timing practices[23] or appraisals of the role of prophecies and predictions in philosophical accounts of time that underpin world politics.[24] In this article, my analytical focus is not so much on the future as such, but on foresight as a form of future-oriented expertise; that is as a way of knowing and constituting the future as a temporal register, amongst political organizations. My contribution therefore speaks most directly to epistemologically constructivist scholarship in and beyond IR that conceptualizes future-oriented practices as productive forms of knowledge and seeks to critically scrutinize how they matter here and now, in the present.

For this strand of scholarship, Ulrich Beck's writings constitute an important reference point. From the late 1980s onwards, Beck cautioned against the proliferation of 'risk' as a way to control the future, infringe on civil liberties, and securitize the present through anticipation.[25] Since then, scholars in critical security studies have illustrated how risk technologies and pre-emption reshape security practices and legitimate their expansion onto new societal domains.[26] While Beck's original account of the risk society emphasized the uninsurability and incalculability of risk, critical research on the proliferation of precautionary risk technologies in the post-9/11 era instead emphasized how they attempt to '"tame" and govern what appears to be ungovernable' through sovereign decisionism and mundane routinized management of 'unease'.[27] Across STS, climate governance, and the sociology of economic expertise, others have studied anticipation through forecasting and prediction that derive from quantitative computational modeling and simulations. This literature emphasizes how anticipatory expertise 'locks in' and naturalizes political assumptions.[28] More recently, a burgeoning IR literature on anticipatory governance has sought to address

[19] Bernstein, Lebow, Stein and Weber, 'God Gave Physics the Easy Problems', pp. 43-76; Robert Jervis, 'The future of world politics: Will it resemble the past?', *International Security*, 16 (1991), pp. 39–73; Kimberly Hutchings, *Time and World Politics: Rethinking the Present* (Manchester University Press, 2008).

[20] Felix Berenskoetter, 'Reclaiming the vision thing: Constructivists as students of the future', *International Studies Quarterly*, 55 (2011), pp. 647–668.

[21] Felix Berenskoetter, 'Anxiety, time, and agency', *International Theory*, 12 (2020), pp. 273–290; Naeem C. Krickel-Choi, 'The concept of anxiety in ontological security studies', *International Studies Review*, 24 (2022); Jennifer Mitzen, 'Ontological security in world politics: State identity and the security dilemma', *European Journal of International Relations*, 12 (2006), pp. 341–370; Brent J. Steele, *Ontological Security in International Relations: Self-Identity and the IR State* (Routledge, 2007); Henrik von Essen and August Danielson, 'A typology of ontological insecurity mechanisms: Russia's military engagement in Syria', *International Studies Review*, 25 (2023); Ayşe Zarakol, 'Ontological (in)security and state denial of historical crimes: Turkey and Japan', *International Relations*, 24 (2010), pp. 3–23.

[22] Andrew R. Hom, 'Silent order: The temporal turn in critical international relations', *Millennium*, 46 (2018), pp. 303–330.

[23] Andrew R. Hom, 'Timing is everything', *International Studies Quarterly*, 62 (2018), pp. 69–79.

[24] Hutchings, *Time and World Politics*.

[25] Ulrich Beck, *Risikogesellschaft: Auf dem Weg in eine andere Moderne* (1986).

[26] Michael J. Williams, '(In)security studies, reflexive modernization and the risk society', *Cooperation and Conflict*, 43 (2008), pp. 57–79; Claudia Aradau and Rens Van Munster, 'Governing terrorism through risk: Taking precautions, (un)knowing the future', *European Journal of International Relations*, 13 (2007), pp. 89–115; Aradau Claudia and Rens van Munster, *Politics of Catastrophe: Genealogies of the Unknown* (Routledge, 2011); Marieke de Goede, 'The politics of privacy in the age of preemptive security: Introduction', *International Political Sociology*, 8 (2014), pp. 100–104; Marieke de Goede, 'Beyond risk: Premediation and the post-9/11 security imagination', *Security Dialogue*, 39 (2008), pp. 155–176; Marieke de Goede, Stephanie Simon, and Marijn Hoijtink, 'Performing preemption', *Security Dialogue*, 45 (2014), pp. 411–422.

[27] Aradau and Van Munster, 'Governing Terrorism Through Risk', pp. 89-115; Didier Bigo, 'Security and immigration: Toward a critique of the governmentality of unease', *Alternatives*, 27 (2002), pp. 63–92.

[28] Stefan Aykut, David Demortain, and Bilel Benbouzid, 'The politics of anticipatory expertise: Plurality and contestation of futures knowledge in governance – introduction to the special issue', *Science and Technology Studies*, 32 (2019), pp. 2–12; Silke Beck and Martin Mahony, 'The IPCC and the politics of anticipation', *Nature Climate Change*, 7 (2017), pp. 311–313;

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how assumptions about the future mark processes of global governance and the work of IOs. This strand of research emphasizes that 'IOs routinely craft visions about which transnational developments are likely to materialise and matter'.[29] Through anticipatory assumptions and expectations, IOs exercise epistemic authority, limiting the realm of possible futures according to their political preferences.[30] In a similar vein, Ariel Colonomos' work on the ethics of prediction and forecasting argues that future experts in world politics produce overly 'conservative', linear forecasts that prioritize stability over the potential for abrupt change, thus reinforcing the status quo and limiting political imagination.[31]

Taken together, these literatures on future-oriented expertise span knowledge practices that implicate assumptions about the future, and such that either seek to render the future less uncertain, or uncertainty more manageable, through notions of risk, probability, forecasting, and predictive approximation. Much ink, thus, has been spilled on critiquing forms of expertise that naturalize *specific* visions of the future as probable and possible, demanding and justifying anticipatory actions in the present. This article, by contrast, turns attention to foresight as an umbrella term for speculative forms of future expertise that embrace deep contingency as a given and make productive use of uncertainty by replacing the notion of 'the future' with visions of multiple futures (in the plural). This 'rediscovery' of the future as 'unknowable' – a realm of radical contingency rather than something to be tamed, anticipated, and controlled – in political institutions has been addressed in some recent contributions to social theory.[32,33] In IR, Peter Katzenstein's recent work has instead echoed this shifting understanding on the future in urging us to abandon the assumption that the world is constituted through controllable risks, and inviting us to accept radical 'uncertainty and an open future' as a 'self-evident' and 'ineluctabl(e)' condition in contemporary world politics.[34] However, despite this burgeoning interest in the future as radically contingent and unknowable, there is a lack of empirically grounded, reflexive, and critical diagnostics of the (onto)politics that such visions of the future unfold, in IOs and elsewhere.

Next to the study of future-oriented practices, my article shares in the overall ambition of this special issue to advance the study of expertise in IR by attending to plural forms of expert knowledge. In existing research, there is a broad consensus that IOs advance claims to expertise as they navigate competitive environments and seek to bolster their own authority and legitimacy.[35] Sociologically inclined scholars have also shown how authoritative expertise comes about in practices of professionals and bureaucrats, NGOs, IOs, states, and (natural) scientists.[36] A closer look at

Cornelius Schubert, 'Situating technological and societal futures: Pragmatist engagements with computer simulations and social dynamics', *Technology in Society*, 40 (2015), pp. 4–13; Benjamin Braun, 'Why models matter: The making and unmaking of governability in macroeconomic discourse', *Journal of Critical Globalisation Studies*, (2014), pp. 48–79.

[29]Henrike Knappe, Anne-Katrin Holfelder, David Löw Beer, and Patrizia Nanz, 'The politics of making and unmaking (sustainable) futures', *Sustainability Science*, 14 (2019), pp. 891–898; John Berten and Matthias Kranke, 'Anticipatory global governance', *Global Society*, 36 (2022), pp. 155–169.

[30]Berten and Kranke, 'Anticipatory global governance', pp. 155-169.

[31]Ariel Colonomos, *Selling the Future: The Paradoxes of Predicting Global Politics* (C Hurst & Co, 2016).

[32]Wenzel, M., Krämer, H., Koch, J., & Reckwitz, A. (2020). Future and Organization Studies: On the rediscovery of a problematic temporal category in organizations. *Organization Studies*, 41(10), 1441–1455.

[33]Oomen, J., Hoffman, J., & Hajer, M. A. (2022). Techniques of futuring: On how imagined futures become socially performative. *European Journal of Social Theory*, 25(2), 252–270.

[34]Katzenstein, *Uncertainty and its Discontents*; Shesterinina and Matejova, *Uncertainty in Global Politics*; Leeds, Mosley, Rosendorff and Zarakol, 'The Future of Global Governance and World Order', pp. S1-S11.

[35]Michael Barnett and Martha Finnemore, *Rules for the World: International Organizations in Global Politics* (Cornell University Press, 2004); Annabelle Littoz-Monnet, *The Politics of Expertise in International Organizations: How International Bureaucracies Use and Produce Knowledge* (Routledge, 2017); Ole Jacob Sending, *The Politics of Expertise: Competing for Authority in Global Governance* (University of Michigan Press, 2015).

[36]Bentley B. Allan, 'Producing the climate: States, scientists, and the constitution of global governance objects', *International Organization*, 71 (2017), pp. 131–162; Rebecca Adler-Nissen and Vincent Pouliot, 'Power in practice: Negotiating the international intervention in Libya', *European Journal of International Relations*, 20 (2014), pp. 889–911.

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foresight as a form of IO expertise extends this well-known picture; it challenges received understanding of IOs as international bureaucracies that exercise rational-legal authority[37] and claims expertise based on notions of scientific objectivity[38] and political neutrality.[39] This is only part of the story. As my analysis illustrates, IO expertise, both past and present, extends to much more eclectic and unexpected sources of knowledge and a wider variety of claims that authorize expertise.[40] Attending to IOs' foresight practices and their genealogical emergence reveals how expertise is also fashioned as such through claims to innovation and imagination, transdisciplinary eclecticism, pluralism, and methodological correctness. It suggests an alternative vision of IOs as consumers and co-producers of eclectic forms of knowledge that transverse the worlds of art and literature, management philosophy, geopolitical strategy, esotericism, and utopianism.

The performativity of the future and foresight as epistemic practice

To think through what is at stake with IOs' embrace of foresight, this article takes performative accounts of the future in social theory and STS as its starting point. Following theorizing in this vein, knowledge that social actors generate about possible futures can be thought of as 'truth candidates': as social imaginaries that become true and real if successfully enacted. As Jeroen Oomen and Martin Hajer argue, the future becomes real 'only to the extent that it is performed'.[41] Future-oriented social practices are consequential since they:

> bring[…] together actors around one or more imagined futures […] through which actors come to share particular orientations for action.[42]

This line of thinking echoes Sheila Jasanoff's work on sociotechnical imaginaries, where she emphasizes how 'collectively held, institutionally stabilized and publicly performed visions of desirable futures' motivate and underwrite social and technological developments.[43] Visions of the future thus become performative to the extent that they establish a common understanding of events that may occur and appropriate ways of acting in response among relevant actors in a global policy domain.[44] As a consequence, interrogating future-oriented practices gains importance for understanding questions of power and political responsibility. More fundamentally, performative theorizing rests on a commitment to constructivist and historical epistemology that does not understand new systems of thought as part of a 'continuous accumulation of knowledge' but as constitutive of the very entities they describe.[45] This suggests that the future itself has a history and can be constituted in different ways depending on the specific place and time.[46] In the analysis below, I therefore pay attention to onto-epistemic commitments in foresight – that is, assumptions about the nature of the future (its assumed properties, its assumed relation to past and present,

[37] Barnett and Finnemore, *Rules for the World*; Max Weber, *Wissenschaft als Beruf* (Duncker & Humblot, 1919); Max Weber, *Max Weber-Studienausgabe: Band I/22,4: Wirtschaft und Gesellschaft: Herrschaft* (Mohr Siebeck, 2009).

[38] Allan, 'Producing the climate', pp. 131–162; Peter M. Haas, 'Introduction: Epistemic communities and international policy coordination', *International Organization*, 46 (1992), pp. 1–35; Annabelle Littoz-Monnet, *Governing through Expertise: The Politics of Bioethics* (Cambridge University Press, 2020).

[39] Marieke Louis and Lucile Maertens, *Why International Organizations Hate Politics: Depoliticizing the World* (Routledge, 2021).

[40] Thereby, I do not address the complex epistemological and ethical questions whether some forms of expertise *are* in fact more or less 'scientific' or politically 'neutral'. Instead, what I am concerned with here is how expertise is validated as such in a social sense.

[41] Tutton, 'Wicked futures', pp. 478-492; Oomen, Hoffman and Hajer, 'Techniques of futuring', pp. 252-270.

[42] Maarten A. Hajer and Peter Pelzer, '2050 – an energetic odyssey: Understanding "techniques of futuring" in the transition towards renewable energy', *Energy Research and Social Science*, 44 (2018), pp. 222–231.

[43] Jasanoff, 'Future imperfect'.

[44] Jasanoff, *The Ethics of Invention*.

[45] Gaston Bachelard, *La Formation de l'Esprit Scientifique* (Librairie Philosophique J. VRIN, 1938); M. Foucault, *The Archeology of Knowledge and the Discourse on Language* (Pantheon Books, 1972)..

[46] Reinhart Koselleck, *Vergangene Zukunft: Zur Semantik geschichtlicher Zeiten* (Suhrkamp, 1988).

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and its epistemological status) – in order to grasp how the future is imagined and enacted in epistemic practices and hence brought to bear on the present. Moreover, I take an interest in how these commitments emerged historically.

In choosing to study foresight in IOs, I also build on more applied work on expertise and anticipation in international institutions. While IOs were traditionally viewed as 'weak' actors in international politics due to their lack of coercive power and material resources, the fact that their status as 'expert' makes them central actors in global governance is now widely recognized. They also inhabit a particularly salient position when it comes to imagining and enacting future worlds: their acknowledged role as knowledge producers[47] and orchestrators[48] render them uniquely positioned to establish common horizons for what events and developments, conflicts, and collaborations the future may or may not hold. As Mattias Kranke and John Berten put it, IOs are 'prognostic experts engaged in imagining and establishing visions of the future'.[49] IOs, thus, inhabit a particularity salient role as futures are crafted and enacted in international politics and hence seem to be particularly worthwhile studying.

To do so, I conceptualize foresight as a bundle of 'epistemic practices' that enable IOs and other actors to construct futures as distinct objects of (non-)knowledge and to carve out ways of manipulating and relating to such futures. This understanding works with Karin Knorr Cetina's concept of epistemic practices, while developing and tailoring it to the phenomenon at hand.[50] For Knorr Cetina, epistemic practices are both knowledge *creating* and knowledge *validating*.[51] They bring forth objects of knowledge that, unlike our colloquial understanding of material 'things', are characterized by 'a lack in completeness of being': they can never be fully known and objective, but keep unfolding.[52] This approach lends itself to an exploration of practices that are directed towards and constitute the future as a quintessentially liminal and elusive object of knowledge and human experience. While I speak of foresight as a way of *knowing* to denote its nature as expertise, I also characterize it as a way of *un*knowing the future since the speculative nature of foresight expertise makes it possible for organizations to relate to plural visions of the future despite their inherent unknowability.

Based on this understanding, in the next section of this article, I trace how foresight is circulated and cultivated across organizations, how it enables IOs to relate to the future (knowledge creation) and how it is authorized as expertise (knowledge validation). As I will illustrate empirically, foresight expertise constitutes the future as plural, radically indeterminate, and beyond the grasp of present knowledge. Visions of the future that foresight brings forth can thus be characterized as speculative since they operate outside of probability considerations and are not seen as deducible from either past or present. Foresight can also be categorized as 'creative' to the extent that such visions are deemed relevant and useful by virtue of sparking imagination and novel 'out of the box' thinking – rather than by virtue of producing 'robust' or reliable forecasts, quantified models, or probability assessments (see below, pp. 15–17, for a discussion of 'creative' and 'robust' future visions[53]).

As I will illustrate later on, this specific way of relating to the future as plural, contingent, and unknowable has a complex history that helps throw light on its politics. In contemporary policy discourse, foresight is often praised as a new and exciting set of tools for IOs and other global governance actors to cultivate. However, I throw critical light on such claim by drawing on the genealogical notion of historical conditions of possibility. This theoretical idiom gives expression to

[47]Littoz-Monnet, *The Politics of Expertise in International Organizations*.

[48]Kenneth W. Abbott, Philipp Genschel, Duncan Snidal, and Bernhard Zangl (eds), *International Organizations as Orchestrators* (Cambridge University Press, 2015).

[49]Berten and Kranke, 'Anticipatory Global Governance', pp. 155-169.

[50]Knorr Cetina, 'Sociality with Objects', pp. 1-30; Knorr Cetina, *Epistemic cultures*.

[51]Karin Knorr Cetina, 'Objectual practice', in T. Schatzki, K. Knorr Cetin, and E. von Savigny (eds), *The Practice Turn in Contemporary Theory* (Routledge, 2001), pp. 184–197.

[52]Knorr Cetina, 'Objectual practice', pp. 184-197.

[53]Berenskoetter, 'Reclaiming the Vision Thing', pp. 647–668.

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a historical understanding of knowledge and ontology: practices of knowing emerge in historically specific contexts that enable them to circulate and be articulated in relation to other practices. Just like the objects they bring forth, practices of knowing themselves are characterized by an emergent ontology.[54] Drawing on this notion and, more broadly, following a genealogical interest in uncovering unexpected, forgotten, and impure beginnings[55] of present practices,[56] my historical account relocates the emergence of onto-epistemic commitments that permeate IO foresight today in competing strands of futurism during the Cold War period.

Next to the analytical toolbox I lay out above, my exploration of foresight expertise in the rest of this article is based on a deliberately heterogenous compilation of empirical materials ('data'), including contemporary IO policy documents and reports, digital platforms, and online events, historical IO archives, futurist writings, and secondary literature on the history of futurisms. These materials were compiled by tracing foresight expertise transversally,[57] that is, across institutional sites and substantive policy fields, and diachronically, that is, across time. There was thus no predefined 'sample' of IOs underpinning my analysis, but instead an interest in reconstructing foresight in IOs as a field of historically contingent epistemic practices. That said, I did not enter this field from 'nowhere'[58]: my entry point was inspired by my previous research and personal expertise on the institutional ecology of the UN, and from there I traced foresight practices across historical and contemporary sites and contexts. Thereby, the delineation of materials to be considered was guided by a methodological concern with qualitative variation and my interpretative reading of the latter was informed by the analytical tools I discuss above along with the methodological principle of qualitative saturation. The empirical examples I use below are situated and illustrative, allowing me to unfold a series of analytical points and explore selected aspects of foresight as expertise in IOs.

Foresight in international organizations: Imagining the future as contingent, plural, and unknowable

'Foresight is no longer optional.'[59]

In the late summer of 2021, at the height of the Covid-19 pandemic, the WHO was under heavy pressure. As a state-centered IO that is closely associated with biomedical expertise and claims to scientific objectivity,[60] WHO was struggling to retain its authority amidst critiques from different camps in global politics. To the vaccine-justice movement, the organization was failing to protect populations in the Global South from death and disease through its inability to halt the financialization of vaccine distribution and Western vaccine nationalism.[61] To many Western states, the organization's beholdenness to China in the fatal first weeks of the previous year had enabled

[54]Mark Bevir, 'Historicism and critique', *Philosophy of the Social Sciences*, 45 (2015), pp. 227–245.

[55]I lend this phrase from Foucault's discussion of Nietzschean geneology as an antiessentialist enterprise that abandons the historian's quest for "true origins" (*Ursprung*) and universal progressive history, instead embracing the "meticulous, and patiently documentary" task of uncovering the numberless beginnings and contingent, power-ridden emergence (*Entstehung*) of the present (Foucault 1977).

[56]Mark Bevir, 'What is genealogy?', *Journal of the Philosophy of History*, 2 (2008), pp. 263–275; Colin Koopman, *Genealogy as Critique Foucault and the Problems of Modernity* (Indiana University Press, 2013); Michel Foucault, 'Nietzsche, genealogy, history', in D. F. Bouchard (ed) *Language, Counter-Memory, Practice: Selected Essays and Interviews* (Cornell University Press, 1977).

[57]On transversality as a methodological practice of 'cutting across' spaces and framings, see Bigo and Walker, 2007, and Hoffmann, 2022.

[58]Thomas Nagel, *The View from Nowhere* (Oxford University Press, 1986).

[59]UN, 'UN Futures Lab: UN Strategic Foresight Guide' (UN, 2023).

[60]Anna Holzscheiter, Thurid Bahr, Laura Pantzerhielm, and Martin Grandjean, 'Positioning among international organizations: Shifting centers of gravity in global health governance', *International Studies Quarterly*, 68 (2024); Adam Kamradt-Scott, 'The evolving WHO: Implications for global health security', *Global Public Health*, 6 (2011), pp. 801–813.

[61]Katerini Storeng, Felix Stein, and Antoine de Bengy Puyvallée, 'COVAX and the many meanings of sharing', *BMJ Global Health*, 6 (2021), pp. 1–4.

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the pandemic to reach its disastrous global proportions.[62] To critics of lockdowns and other pandemic response policies, the verdict was even harsher: WHO was in the midst of advancing to an authoritarian global emergency government.[63]

In this tense atmosphere, epidemiologists and other highly skilled specialists from the WHO Science Department launched a brand-new initiative. Noting that 'accelerated COVID-19 transmission has been reported from many parts of the world', they described the purpose of the new webinar series as a:

> journey of imagining the future of infectious threats (…) to mitigate the ongoing and anticipated risks of COVID-19 and other infectious threats.[64]

The methodology that the initiative would adopt was *not* epidemiological. Instead, the experts assembled for four consecutive workshops would use 'scenarios' and 'horizon scanning'.[65] As the first seminar took place in late October, a professional with the title 'senior foresight strategist' gave a presentation on 'the usefulness of foresight for improved pandemic preparedness'. The group of senior WHO scientists who were present throughout the Zoom session listened carefully, asked follow-up questions, and jointly pondered issues such as 'What is foresight?', 'What are the methodologies?', 'Why is foresight useful?', and 'What are the practical uses?'[66]

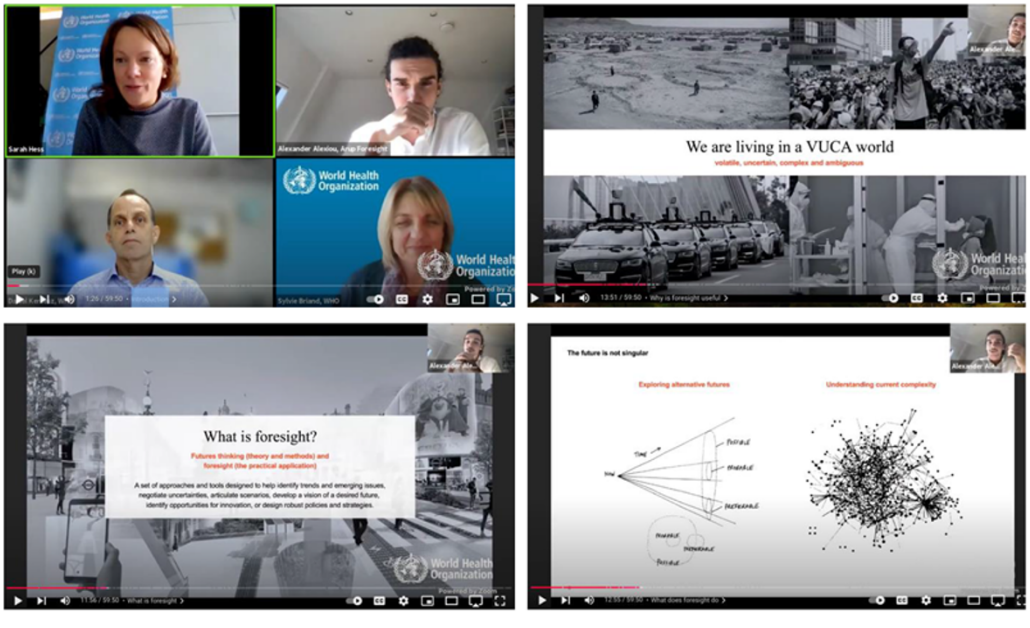

Figure 1. Collage of stills from WHO foresight project series, 'Webinar 1: 'The Usefulness of Foresight for Improved Pandemic Preparedness'.[67]

[62] Theodore M. Brown and Susan Ladwig, 'COVID-19, China, the World Health Organization, and the limits of international health diplomacy', *American Journal of Public Health*, 110 (2020), pp. 1149–1151.

[63] Giorgio Agamben, *Where Are We Now? The Epidemic as Politics* (Rowman & Littlefield, 2021).

[64] WHO, 'Imagining the Future: Conversations on the COVID-19 Pandemic and Other Infectious Threats' (World Health Organization, 2021); WHO, 'EPI-WIN is Hosting a Series of Webinars on the Infectious Hazards Foresight Initiative' (World Health Organization, 2021).

[65] WHO, 'Imagining the future'.

[66] WHO, 'The Usefulness of Foresight for Improved Pandemic Preparedness (Webinar 1: Foresight Project Series)' (World Health Organization, 2021).

[67] WHO, 'The Usefulness of Foresight for Improved Pandemic Preparedness (Webinar 1: Foresight Project Series)'.

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As this example illustrates, contemporary IOs view foresight as a relevant toolkit as they seek to tackle urgent policy problems, navigate uncertainties, and retain credibility amidst flux and contingency. Why had the world been so ill-prepared to face the Covid-19 pandemic? Could approaching the future in a way that took into account its non-singular nature make the world and WHO fit for the next crisis? Perhaps, these were some of the questions going through the minds of WHO officials.

Foresight as epistemic practices in IOs: Creating expertise

With its embrace of future thinking, the WHO is no exception among contemporary international institutions. The UN is another case in point. In September 2024, the organization held a star-studded conference entitled 'Summit for the Future' at the New York headquarters. This major global summit had been announced in the Secretary General's report 'Our Common Agenda' with the declared purpose of 'turbocharging action on the Sustainable Development Goals'.[68] Steeped in foresight vocabulary, the report sketched two alternative futures for the world: 'a breakthrough scenario' which would lead to 'a green, safer and prosperous future' and 'a scenario of breakdown and perpetual crisis'.[69] While global public debate around the Summit of the Future focused on the political declarations it produced in Pact for the Future, Global Digital Compact, and the Declaration on Future Generations,[70] work on developing the appropriate methods and skills to create 'a culture of foresight'[71] was already well under way in the organization.

In 2023, the UN 'Futures Lab Network' had been established to 'help the UN System and beyond embrace futures thinking and strategic foresight'.[72] In the same year, the Secretary General launched 'UN 2.0', an initiative dedicated to 'rejuvenating' the UN through 'cutting-edge skills for the twenty-first century'.[73] Next to skills in data science, digital technology, innovation, and behavioral science, UN 2.0 aims to promote the development of foresight expertise:

> instilling a culture of foresight means equipping ourselves with the capacities to discern emerging trends, anticipate potential shifts, and respond proactively.[74]

These practices on the part of WHO and the UN are indicative of a broader phenomenon, where IOs across policy fields, such as international peace and security[75], sustainable development[76], environmental governance,[77] economic[78] and regional cooperation[79], engage in the creation of foresight expertise as a way to relate to the future. They exemplify, how, in the worlds of contemporary IOs, we encounter a range of practices and artifacts geared towards cultivating and circulating expertise across institutions and policy fields that constructs plural futures as objects of (non-)knowledge. For instance, the UN Futures Lab lists foresights initiatives across UN programs, funds, and agencies,[80] while UN 2.0 includes an interactive world map that allows users to browse foresight initiatives around the globe, whilst featuring articles on best practice

[68] UN, 'Our Common Agenda: Report by the Secretary-General', in (Geneva: United Nations, 2021).
[69] UN, 'Our Common Agenda: Report by the Secretary-General'.
[70] UN, 'Summit for the Future Outcome Documents, September 2024: Pact for the Future, Global Digital Compact, and the Declaration on Future Generations' (United Nations, 2024).
[71] UN, 'UN 2.0. Quintet of Change' (United Nations, 2024).
[72] UN, 'UN Futures Lab Network: Exploring the Future Shaping Today and Beyond' (United Nations, 2024).
[73] UN, 'UN 2.0. Quintet of Change'.
[74] UN, 'UN 2.0. Quintet of Change'.
[75] NATO, 'Allied Command Transformation'.
[76] UNDP, 'Foresight Manual'.
[77] UNEP, 'UNEP Foresight Roadmap and Upcoming Events' (UNEP, 2024).
[78] OECD, 'Strategic Foresight at the OECD'.
[79] AU, *The Africa Governance Report 2021*; EC, *2023 Strategic Foresight Report, European Commission*.
[80] UN, 'Foresight work from across the United Nations system', in (2024).

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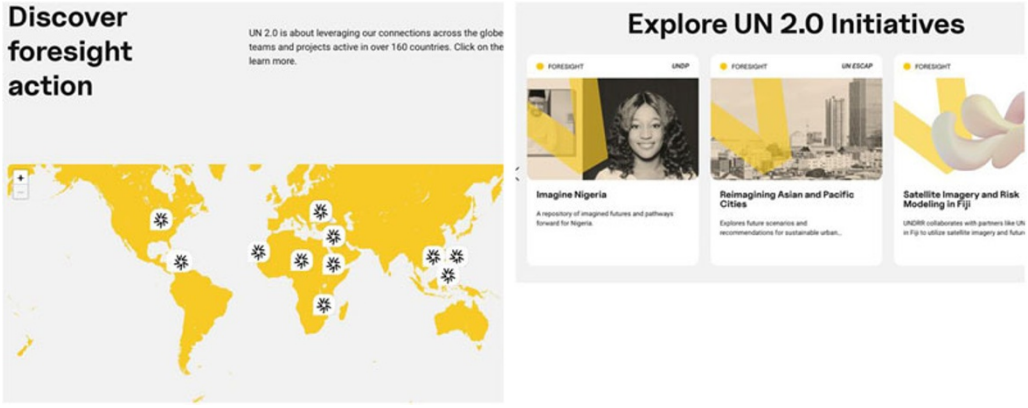

Figure 2. UN 2.0 Interactive map 'Discover foresight action' and preview of articles 'Explore UN 2.0 initiatives'.[82]

projects – hence facilitating the movement and proliferation of knowledge across institutional scales and boundaries,[81] see Figure 2.

Efforts at ordering also pervade the creation of foresight expertise in contemporary IOs and their surrounding organizational fields. For instance, last year, the International Science Council published a report it had prepared in cooperation with the UN Environment Programme.[83] As 'foresight is receiving growing attention on the international stage as a set of tools to support proactive sustainable development', the report addresses what is described as 'a need to reflect on the field of foresight and horizon scanning itself (…) through reviewing the landscape of available tools and methods'.[84] Similarly, the UN recently released a 'UN Strategic Foresight Guide' that describes foresight methods and orders them by dividing them into three different 'areas of application': namely, 'make sense of change', 'imagine possible futures', and 'take action'.[85] To summarize, the world of contemporary IOs is marked by practices that cultivate, circulate, and order foresight, hence creating it a specific form of future-oriented expertise and enabling it to travel and proliferate across individual organizations and substantive policy fields.

Foresight as epistemic practices in IOs: Validating expertise

How, in the midst of this proliferation and velocity, is foresight validated and authorized as expertise? Compared to more well-studied modes of IO knowledge production, foresight is thoroughly eclectic. It is authorized through claims to innovation, imagination, pluralism, and 'out of the box'-thinking, rather than claims to objective or universal truths. Indeed, futures research has long been marked by a certain disdain for formal academic training and dull disciplinary discussions, instead valuing knowledge that is fashioned as novel, creative, and unexcepted.[86]

Let us explore this point by returning to the WHO foresight webinar that I mentioned above. At the beginning of the seminar, Director of the WHO Epidemic and Pandemic Preparedness and Prevention Department, Sylvie Briand, offered a few opening remarks. She recounted how pandemic preparedness had tended to move from crisis to crisis and sought to explain the relevance of foresight for moving from a 'reactive' to a 'proactive' approach:

[81] UN, 'Discover foresight action', in (2024).
[82] UN, 'Discover foresight action'.
[83] ISC, 'A Guide to Anticipation'.
[84] ISC, 'A Guide to Anticipation'.
[85] UN, 'UN Futures Lab'.
[86] Jenny Andersson, *The Future of the World: Futurology, Futurists, and the Struggle for the Post Cold War Imagination* (Oxford University Press, 2018).

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> Every time we face a major event like that, we often do an action review, and we draw the lessons from the response, and we fix what has not worked in this outbreak. From my experience I have noticed that usually the next epidemic or pandemic is completely new, it is a new animal and then we are not necessarily ready, prepared for it. So, I think this is why we wanted really to add (…) this new and exciting innovative foresight initiative which is about imagining the future of infectious threat for the next 3 to 5 years, so that we can think 'out of the box'. And the 'out of the box' is really difficult because we all have our own cognitive biases and tend to do more of the same (…) and remain in our comfort zone (…). But sometimes the solution lies somewhere else. And to find this new solution, innovative solution, we need really also to think about different scenarios for the future. So this is what foresight is about.[87], 4 min 45 sec – 6 min 20 sec

As Briand's line of reasoning illustrates, foresight is validated as expertise through claims to novelty, creativity, and innovation. It is fashioned as a way of ridding ourselves of biases and the frustrating task of seeking to learn from the past, instead opting to engage in new, 'fresh' ways of knowing that engage our capacity to imagine and to speculate.

Related features of how foresight is validated as expertise are allusions to methodological correctness. Formalized and explicit procedures that guide and structure foresight practices are numerous. They tend to be elaborate and specific, carrying a distinct and recognizable name, such as 'horizon scanning', 'delphi exercise', 'scenario thinking', 'science fictioning', 'backcasting', or 'policy gaming'.[88] This clearly delineated methodological nature of foresight (the fact that is possible to refer to '*the* horizon scanning technique') means that foresight travels lightly: it is packaged, objectified, and commodified in ways that make it transverse organizational boundaries and policy fields, as an attractive procedural toolbox for IOs and other actors to cultivate.

Moreover, successfully embodying the role as a 'foresight expert' involves illustrating the eclectic and boundary-transversing nature of one's knowing. This is noteworthy since it contrasts with the established notion that expertise is constituted as such through exclusivity and specialization.[89] As an illustration, let us consider the list of authors in the UNESCO foresight report 'Transforming the future: Anticipation in the 21st century'.[90] Besides IO professionals, diplomats, and bureaucrats, the report was authored by academics of various disciplines, professional futurists, and consultants, along with designers, poets, and artists. For example, one of the contributors, Shermon Cruz, is described as 'a professional futurist, a climate reality leader, a certified business continuity professional'.[91] Another contributor, Kewulay Kamara, is described as 'a poet/storyteller, multi-media artist and lecturer', who had 'featured in The New York Times', directed an 'epic poetry documentary', and given 'a Ted TEDxUNC Talk on the uses of storytelling and foresight'.[92] In these depictions, eclecticism and transgressions between realms of expertise are emphasized and valued. In fact, these short author bios show how people travel across professional fields and categories throughout their careers. Riel Miller, the editor of the publication, offers an apt illustration here. Miller's professional biography includes research and teaching positions with academic institutions in Canada, Norway, France, and other countries, board memberships and roles in professional futurist associations, such as World Futures Studies Federation and Association of Professional Futurists, work as an independent consultant, and various positions as a policy advisor with OECD and UNESCO, including as 'Head of Futures Literacy at UNESCO'.[93]

[87] WHO, 'The usefulness of foresight for improved pandemic preparedness (Webinar 1: Foresight project series)', in (2021).
[88] ISC, 'A Guide to Anticipation'; Jerome C. Glenn and T. J. Gordon, 'Futures Research Methodology Version 3.0' (2009).
[89] Eyal, 2013.
[90] UNESCO (ed), *Transforming the Future: Anticipation in the 21st Century* (United Nations Educational, Scientific and Cultural Organisation, 2018).
[91] UNESCO (ed), *Transforming the Future*.
[92] UNESCO (ed), *Transforming the Future*.
[93] UNESCO (ed), *Transforming the Future*.

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Figure 3. Stills from the video 'What is Strategic Foresight?'.[94]

How IO foresight constitutes the future: On onto-epistemic commitments

Despite its eclectic and boundary-transversing nature, foresight comes with distinct onto-epistemic commitments that also set it apart from more well-researched future-oriented forms of expertise. Pertinent research on forecasting, modeling, and risk technologies has illustrated how such practices seek to render the future calculable and manageable through probability, approximation, and naturalization (see above, pp. 5–6). However, in foresight, the future is posited and acted upon as plural, contingent, and ultimately unknowable. To delve deeper into the question of *how* foresight allows for IOs to relate to the future and how it constitutes the future as a temporal register, let us consider some of the tropes and underpinning assumptions that recur across foresight practices in contemporary IOs.

A good place to start is the rejection of prediction. There is a firm sense across IOs' engagements with foresight that the future cannot be deduced from past experience in a 'linear' manner. No matter how much data or how sophisticated the methods, the future remains elusive: 'the future is not an extrapolation of the past'.[95] Foresight embarks from a view of both present and future as ontologically contingent. This becomes visible in diagnoses of polycrisis, uncertainty, and accelerating change that often mark the metaphorical place where foresight is seen as useful and needed. Consider, by way of illustration, the notion that 'we are living in a VUCA world', where 'VUCA' stands for 'volatile, uncertain, complex and ambiguous'[96] (see Figure 1 above). Another vivid illustration of this commitment to uncertainty, flux, and complexity can be found in a 2024 video published by UN Global Pulse, an innovation lab created by the Secretary General as part of UN 2.0.[97] In the video, moving graphic illustrations and keywords light the screen (for a still, see Figure 3 below) and ambient music plays in the background, as a narrator tells us:

> as the rate of change grows exponentially, and multiple crises compile on a global scale, we struggle to keep up. Soon, the gap between what is happening, what's to come and what we

[94]UN Global Pulse, 'What is Strategic Foresight: A Strategic Foresight Approach', in (2024).
[95]UN, 'UN Futures Lab'.
[96]WHO, 'The usefulness of foresight for improved pandemic preparedness (Webinar 1: Foresight project series)', in (2021).
[97]UN Global Pulse, 'UN Global Pulse – About Us' (United Nations, 2024).

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> can do about it significantly widens. Bridging that gap in today's increasingly complex landscape can feel like an impossible task, especially for policy makers. But there is a way forward. Strategic foresight is a systematic approach to dealing with uncertainty.[98]

Foresight therefore grapples with uncertainty and unknowability as inherent features of the (future) world that need to be cultivated and understood. This sets foresight apart from existing scholarly diagnoses of risk technologies and forecasting techniques that seek to tame uncertainty by approximating and anticipating more or less likely futures.[99] In a pertinent study of more speculative forms of risk technologies that transverse security and economic governance, Louise Amoore diagnoses a subtle shift from the management of risks based on their relative probability, towards a concern with low-probability high-risk events.[100] This shift from 'prevent[ing]' to 'preempt[ing]' dangerous events[101] loosens the grip of probability calculations and emphasizes possibility as a relevant horizon for future-oriented governance.

Foresight takes this logic further by concerning itself with multiple unlikely, but principally plausible, futures. This is closely connected to the idea that the future is at once plural and created. While it is impossible to predict which, out of many possible, futures will be realized, futures are nonetheless products of human efforts and imagination:

> Every 'what if' sparks new ideas and drives us to create a better tomorrow. What if we embraced uncertainty and complexity with imagination? By exploring multiple futures, we gain fresh perspectives on present challenges and opportunities.[102]

In fact, futurist professionals understand foresight methods not only as tools for imagining futures or relating to its plural possibilities, but as devices that shape and *create* the future. Jim Dator, a prominent futurist who is associated with the Manoa school of futures studies, gives expression to this sentiment:

> Futures visioning is not just about imagining a preferred future. It is about using that vision to decide what to do now in the present in order to move towards the preferred future.[103]

Finally, futures thinking goes along with a commitment to viewing – and ethically valuing – current practices in relation to long-term futures, rather than a responsiveness to immediate risks, dangers, needs, or opportunities. As a recent EU foresight report put it:

> integrating long-term goals into short to medium-term decision-making can boost our chances of leaving a world that is in better shape to the next generation.[104]

There is thus a sentiment that possible long-term futures ought to be central to current decisions and that they are ontologically decisive in the sense that 'we' (humanity, as a species) need to relate to the long-term to survive, be prosperous, and flourish. There is value in 'provok(ing) long-term thinking'.[105]

Against this backdrop, foresight can be understood as a bundle of epistemic practices that constitute the future as plural, contingent, and unknowable. In a time where diagnoses of a deepening

[98] UN Global Pulse, 'What is Strategic Foresight: A Strategic Foresight Approach', in (2024).

[99] Williams, '(In)security studies, reflexive modernization and the risk society', pp. 57–79; Claudia Aradau and Rens Van Munster, 'Governing terrorism through risk', pp. 89–115; Aykut, Demortain and Benbouzid, 'The Politics of Anticipatory Expertise', pp. 2-12; Silke Beck and Martin Mahony, 'The IPCC and the politics of anticipation', pp. 311–313.

[100] Louise Amoore, *The Politics of Possibility: Risk and Security Beyond Probability* (Duke University Press, 2013).

[101] Louise Amoore, *The Politics of Possibility*.

[102] UN, 'UN Futures Lab Network'.

[103] Jim Dator, 'Alternative futures at the Manoa school', *Journal of Futures Studies*, 14 (2009), pp. 1–18.

[104] ESPAS, 'Global Trends to 2040: Choosing Europe's Future' (European Strategy and Policy Analysis System, 2024).

[105] Jake F. Dunagan, 'Jim Dator: The living embodiment of futures studies', *Journal of Futures Studies*, 18 (2013), pp. 131–138.

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polycrisis abound[106] and IOs face a variety of pressures,[107] it seems attractive for IOs to equip themselves with expertise designed to approach the uncertainty of the world and the elusive, unknowable nature of the future with ease and competence: 'We may not control uncertainty, but we can shape how we face it'.[108] How did this specific way of (un)knowing and relating to the future emerge historically and take on its current form?

In the next section, I venture into IOs' historical archives and scholarly writings on the history of futurisms to examine how some of the onto-epistemic commitments that mark IO foresight practices today crystallized during the second half of the 20th century. Based on the theoretical premise that practices of knowing are constitutive and historically contingent, I engage in a history of the present that seeks to destabilize taken-for-granted assumptions about cherished contemporary practices through 'counter-memory and re-serialization'.[109] Rather than accepting claims about the 'fresh', innovative, and novel nature of IO foresight in the present, I place it in different historical series by tracing out some of its 'numberless beginnings'.[110]

The unexpected origins of IO futures

In contrast to other powerful repertoires of knowledge that mark the work of IOs, such as climate science or epidemiology, foresight did not emerge in the world of the natural sciences and scientific advisory bodies. Instead, a walk to the historical archive shows that foresight has a complex history of emergence, with heterogenous beginning dispersed across science fiction and Cold War strategic competition, business philosophy, and spiritual teachings.[111] For instance, a modern classic in foresight is the 1962 speculative monograph *Profiles of the Future: An Inquiry into the Limits of the Possible*. It was written by Arthur C. Clarke – a prolific science fiction author to whom we also owe the screenplay for the well-known 1968 Kubrick movie *2001: A Space Odyssey* – and it features imaginative narratives about distant futures of space travel, technology, and human civilization.[112] Other works in the foresight canon include French oil executive Pierre Wack's writings from the late 1970s onwards. They tell a corporate 'success story' of how the Shell company had been surprisingly well equipped to deal with the 1973 oil crisis that severely impacted vast parts of the industry. In contrast to the 'linear' planning activities of its competitors, so the story goes, Shell had embraced creative thinking on the uncertainty and plurality of futures.[113] The broader genealogy of 20th century futurisms from which foresight emerged also extended to geopolitical theorizing on nuclear warfare and Cold War strategy,[114] while connections to esotericism and spiritual traditions included early ecologism, Quakers, scientology, and the European and North American hippie movement.[115]

[106]Michael Lawrence, Thomas Homer-Dixon, Scott Janzwood, Johan Rockström, Ortwin Renn, and Jonathan F. Donges, 'Global polycrisis: The causal mechanisms of crisis entanglement', *Global Sustainability*, 7 (2024), p. e6.

[107]Klaus Dingwerth, Antonia Witt, Ina Lehmann, Ellen Reichel, and Tobias Weise, *International Organizations Under Pressure: Legitimating Global Governance in Challenging Times* (Oxford University Press, 2024).

[108]UN, 'UN Futures Lab Network'.

[109]William Walters, *Governmentality: Critical Encounters* (Routledge, 2012).

[110]Michel Foucault, 'Nietzsche, genealogy, history', in D. F. Bouchard (ed) *Language, Counter-Memory, Practice: Selected Essays and Interviews* (Cornell University Press, 1977).

[111]Wendy L. Schultz, 'A brief history of futures', *World Futures Review*, 7 (2015), pp. 324–331.

[112]Arthur C. Clarke, 'Profiles on the Future' (Scientific Book Club, 1962).

[113]Wendy L. Schultz, 'A brief history of futures', *World Futures Review*, 7 (2015), pp. 324–331.; Pierre Wack, 'Scenarios: Uncharted waters ahead', *Harvard Business Review* (September 1985); Pierre Wack, 'Scenarios: Shooting the rapids', *Harvard Business Review* (November 1985).

[114]Olaf Helmer, 'The game-theoretical approach to organization theory', *Synthese*, 15 (1963), pp. 245–253; Herman Kahn, *On Thermonuclear War* (Routledge, 1960); Herman Kahn and Anthony J. Wiener, *The Year 2000: A Framework for Speculation on the Next Thirty-Three Years* (Macmillan, 1967).

[115]Inayatullah, 'Futures studies: Theories and methods', pp. 36–66.; Jenny Andersson, *The Future of the World: Futurology, Futurists, and the Struggle for the Post Cold War Imagination* (Oxford University Press, 2018); Jenny Andersson, 'The great future debate and the struggle for the world', *American Historical Review*, 5 (2012), pp. 1411–1430.

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Cold war futurology and the birth of futures studies

Even a brief consideration of some the heterogenous historical beginnings of foresight, therefore, lends further support to a vision of IO expertise as extending beyond forms of knowledge that are sustained and authorized through notions of scientific objectivity and bureaucratic rationality. It renders understandable how foresight came to be authorized through claims to eclecticism, creativity, and innovation, and how it is that it travels so lightly across organizations and policy fields. Yet, to understand the historical conditions of possibility for foresight to emerge as a specific way of (un)knowing to the future, it is useful to revisit a particular point in its genealogy: the establishment of 'futures studies' in the early 1970s as an activist, utopian, and aesthetic counter-project to 'scientific' Cold War futurology.

In the preceding decades, futurology had been invented as a science of forecasting and prediction, and as such it had become a vital toolbox in Cold War power struggles. US scientists at the RAND corporation and the Hudson Institute had developed scenario methods, war games, and simulations as strategic thinking tools that would allow the West to stay 'ahead' in the event of a hot Cold War.[116] In France, Gaston Berger invented *la prospective* as a 'science of forecasting'.[117] With the political upheavals of 1968, the rise of the New Left, peace protests, and the hippie movement, block politics fatigue and new kinds of utopianism swept the West. Against this backdrop, the very first 'International Futures Studies Conference' was held in Oslo in 1967 under the aegis of the French futurist society 'Humanité 2000' and a group of European peace activists, researchers, and intellectuals.[118] By 1973, the World Futures Studies Federation (WFSF) was founded as a forum for futurists of a more activist inclination who sought to pluralize and democratize futurology. These more radical futurists sought to open the field to utopian, normative forms of speculation and creativity, as opposed to the 'planning' activities of 'technocratic elites'.[119] As historian Jenny Andersson puts it, futures studies were 'a counter reaction to futurology and protest against the Cold War world order'.[120]

To explore this historical lineage, let us consider an instructive document from the archive. A few years after the conference in Oslo, UNITAR commisioned a report that charted the budding field of futures studies.[121] The authors were artist John McHale, who the art critic Reyner Banham would later call 'the father of pop',[122] and his wife Magda Cordell McHale, herself an artist who would move on to a career as a futurist academic in the subsequent decades.[123] The UNITAR report and other works in the same genre by the McHales are noteworthy for several reasons. First, they show how the fine arts constituted another piece in the mosaic of foresight's eclectic field of emergence. To illustrate the porous borders between artistic practice, social analysis, and the emerging field of futures studies during the Cold War period, Figure 4 presents a collage of selected writings and artworks by the McHales.

Second, the 1976 report by the McHales also provides an apt illustration of how the onto-epistemic commitments that continue to mark IO foresight today crystalized historically. Noting an expansion of future-oriented activitivies and organizations, they differentiated between 'forecasting', 'long-range planning', and 'futures studies' as fieldsof inquiry that were 'woven together

[116] O. Olaf Helmer, 'The game-theoretical approach to organization theory', *Synthese*, 15 (1963), pp. 245–253; Herman Kahn, *On Thermonuclear War* (Routledge, 1960); Andersson, 'The great future debate and the struggle for the world', pp. 1411–1430.

[117] Hugues de Jouvenel, 'Futuribles: Origins, philosophy, and practices – anticipation for action', *World Futures Review*, 11 (2018), pp. 8–18; Gaston Berger, 'Sciences humaines et prevision', *La Revue des Deux Mondes*, 1 (1957), pp. 16–26.

[118] Hugues de Jouvenel, *Art of Conjecture* (Basic Books, 1972).

[119] Richard A. Slaughter, 'World Futures Studies Federation: Histories and futures', *Futures*, 37 (2005), pp. 349–353.

[120] Andersson, *The Future of the World*.

[121] John McHale and Magda Cordell McHale, 'Futures studies: An international survey', *Ekistics*, 41 (1976), pp. 300–306.

[122] Reyner Banham, *The Expendable Ikon: Work by John McHale* (Buffalo Fine Arts Academy, 1984).

[123] Johnson, 'Magda Cordell McHale, 86, futurist thinker, is dead', *New York Times* (2008).

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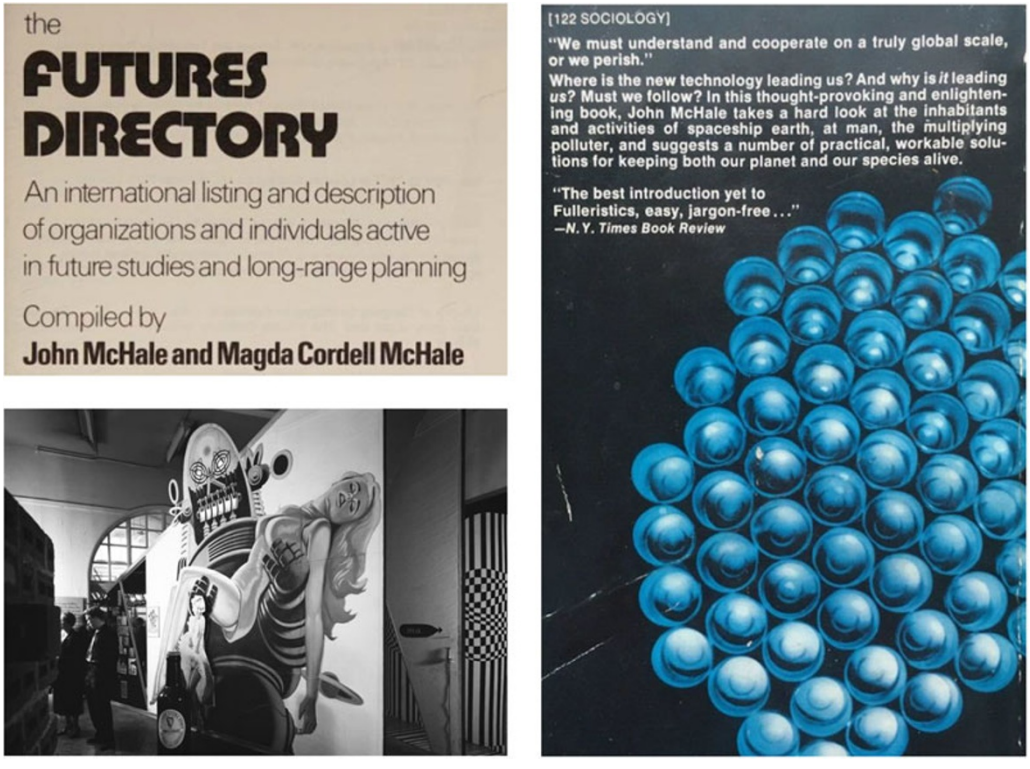

Figure 4. Collage of publications and artworks by Magda Cordell McHale and John McHale. Upper left: detail of the first page of the publication "The Futures Directory"[124]; bottom left: group exhibition "This is Tomorrow", installation view, Whitechapel Art Gallery, London 1956[125]; and to the right: back cover of the monograph "The Future of the Future".[126]

but […] have certain independent aspects'.[127] While forecasting assumed 'definable causal relations between events through which one can predict their future states – with varying levels of probability of occurrence', long-range planning was concerned 'with the organization of events within the next five to ten years', its 'horizons' being limited 'by its functional relationship to some specific sector of the society (and) implied value assumptions'.[128]

In contrast to such mainstream futurological approaches, the report described futures studies as a more 'open ended and less definable process' that was 'open to speculation', oriented toward the long term[129], and worked with 'explicit sets of value considerations'[130]. The purpose of such an alternative approach to the future, they explained, was:

> not to prophesy what a specific future will be, but rather more to explore the plurality of future(s) states which may be contingent upon our actions or accessible to our choice.[131]

[124]McHale, J., & McHale, M. C. (1977). *The Futures directory: an international listing and description of organizations and individuals active in futures studies and long-range planning*. IPC Science and Technology Press, Westview Press.

[125]McHale, J., Voelcker, J., & Lambert, S. (1956). *This is tomorrow' exhibition, Whitechapel Art Gallery, London: Group 2 exhibit*., Digital image: John Maltby / RIBA Collections. RIBA Ref No: RIBA140059.

[126]McHale, J. (1969). *The Future of the Future*. George Braziller Inc.

[127]McHale and McHale, 'Futures studies', pp. 300–306.

[128]McHale and McHale, 'Futures studies', pp. 300–306.

[129]McHale and McHale, 'Futures Studies', pp. 300-306

[130]McHale and McHale, 'Futures Studies', pp. 300-306

[131]McHale and McHale, 'Futures Studies', pp. 300-306

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Such a vision of plural and contingent futures, they continued, was better suited to the modern world. In fact, 'unilinear and short-term approaches [were] no longer appropriate', since:

> (w)e live in a highly interdependent world system whose complex interrelationships must now be viewed in terms of their longer term consequences and implications. The common awareness and sense of urgency have generated much debate regarding the alternative kinds of futures which we may face.[132]

As this example illustrates and renders tangible, the emerging field of futures studies thus sought to set itself apart from what they saw as the futurological mainstream's preoccupation with prediction and strategy. Thereby, it emphasized the unknowability of the future (in the singular), the impossibility of prediction, the plurality of possible futures, and the role of imagination and creativity in envisioning paths for long-term peaceful coexistence and flourishing of mankind.[133] It was thus in this historical moment that some of the onto-epistemic commitments that permeate IO foresight today took form. This was premised on a rift between different camps of futurists who sought to know and relate to the future in contrasting ways: utopian and aesthetically inclined 'activists' and elitist professionals who viewed futurology as a science of prediction and forecasting. Indeed, the McHales wrote about a 'dichotomy between various futures workers'.[134] On the one hand, they explained, the field was characterized by a 'drive towards increased specialization and professionalism'.[135] But on the other hand, there was also an opposing tendency among futurists who wanted to:

> engage the broadest and most diverse array of persons, both professionals and non-professionals, with futures-oriented thinking and action.[136]

In short, there was a 'polarization between scholar and activist'.[137] Seen in this light, the cultivation of the contingent and plural, creative, and unexpected in futures thinking that contemporary foresight experts embrace and the taming of uncertainty through prediction, risk, and probability that they tend to reject, must be viewed as reflective of two competing strands in futurist discourse as it developed in the late 20th century. Early futures studies thus foreshadowed the ontopolitics of foresight in the present and pioneered ways of validating expertise through allusions to creativity and pluralism, rather than science or objectivity.

Now, where do IOs fit into the story? What was their position within the historical 'stage of forces' in Cold War futurism that allowed for speculative foresight, as a new way of (un)knowing the future, to be articulated in relation to other practices? The next section addresses the place of world politics and IOs in early futures studies.

The place of IOs and world politics in the history of foresight

Another characteristic of early futures studies that is noteworthy when viewed from the present is the emphasis that was placed on problems of world politics and peaceful human coexistence. To explore this point, let us dwell on the historical event of the first International Futures Studies Conference of 1967 and consider the social identities and shared problematizations motivating its participants. Set in beautiful scenery over the fjord of Oslo and dedicated to the theme *Mankind 2000*, this gathering brought together a heterodox group of planners, futurists, peace researchers, activists, artists, and journalists. One of the organizers was Johan Galtung, whom most readers of

[132] McHale and McHale, 'Futures studies', pp. 300–306.

[133] Hugues de Jouvenel, 'Futuribles', pp. 8–18; R. Jungk and J. Galtung (eds), *Mankind 2000* (International Peace Research Institute, Institut für Zukunftsfragen, 1970).

[134] McHale and McHale, 'Futures studies', pp. 300–306.

[135] John McHale and Magda McHale, 'An assessment of futures studies worldwide', *Futures*, 8 (1976), pp. 135–145.

[136] McHale and McHale, 'An assessment of futures studies worldwide', pp. 135–145.

[137] McHale and McHale, 'An assessment of futures studies worldwide', pp. 135–145.

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this journal might recognize as the 'founding father' of peace research.[138] As a political scientist and peace researcher, he was not alone at the conference. In fact, several chapters of the *Mankind 2000* report that Galtung edited together with German journalist and peace activist Robert Jungk following the conference read a lot like an IR journal of the day. Galtung's own contribution was entitled 'On the Future of the International System'.[139] In the rest of the report, chapters with similarly pertinent titles, such as 'International Planning of Peaceful Economic Development'[140] or 'A Proposal for Curtailing Small Wars',[141] featured next elaborations on themes that must have sounded less familiar to an IR audience, such as 'Future Applications of Cybernetics'[142] or 'Communication in the Year 2000'.[143] Problems of international cooperation, war, and peace were thus all but absent in the early days of futures studies.

What is more, a closer inspection of further documents and artifacts from the historical archive reveals that IOs themselves were closely entangled with different strands of futurist discourse. In practical terms, this intermingling took on various forms, from conferences and workshops to research programs, grants, and consultancies. As I mentioned in passing above, the McHales both took on the role as foresight consultants for UNITAR.[144] In the early 1970s, the organization hosted regular seminars with other activist, experimental futurists, such as Jim Dator and Robert Jungk.[145] UNESCO's engagement with the field provides another illustrative example. In the UN context, the organization stands out as perhaps the most significant long-term space for the cultivation of speculative foresight and alternative futures. For instance, Dutch futurist Fred Polak, whose 1955 monograph *The Image of the Future* popularized the notion of multiple possible future worlds and was later to be canonized as a futures studies 'classic',[146] was a recipient of multiple fellowships from the organization.[147] From the late 1960s onwards, UNESCO also published regular reports on futures and futurology, such as a highly aestheticized publication 'What future for futurology?'[148]that featured works by Jungk, Helmer, Galtung, Polak and (John) McHale; and other avid futurists of the day such as Bertrand de Jouvenel, Ossip K. Flechtheim and Kenneth E. Boulding (see, Figure 5). Surveying recent trends in the field, the report quoted Helmer declaring that:

> the fatalistic concept of an unforeseeable and unavoidable future (…) is being progressively abandoned. We are beginning to realize that there are a great number of possible futures, and that appropriate action can influence these possibilities in different ways.[149]

[138]Johan Galtung, 'Violence, peace, and peace research', *Journal of Peace Research*, 6 (1969), pp. 167–191; Henrik Urdal, 'Inspiration from a Father: Johan Galtung Interviewed by Henrik Urdal' (2019).

[139]Johan Galtung, 'On the future of the international system', in R. Jungk and J. Galtung (eds), *Mankind 2000* (International Peace Research Institute, Institut für Zukunftsfragen, 1970), pp. 12–14.

[140]Seymour Melman, 'International planning of peaceful economic development', in R. Jungk and J. Galtung (eds), *Mankind 2000* (International Peace Research Institute, Institut für Zukunftsfragen, 1970), pp. 42–47.

[141]Charles E. Osgood, 'A proposal for curtailing small wars', in R. Jungk and J. Galtung (eds), *Mankind 2000* (International Peace Research Institute, Institut für Zukunftsfragen, 1970), pp. 54–65.

[142]Silvio Ceccato, 'Future applications of cybernetics', in R. Jungk and J. Galtung (eds), *Mankind 2000* (International Peace Research Institute, Institut für Zukunftsfragen, 1970), pp. 205–211.

[143]K. Steinbruch, 'Communication in the year 2000', in R. Jungk and J. Galtung (eds), *Mankind 2000* (International Peace Research Institute, Institut für Zukunftsfragen, 1970), pp. 165–170.

[144]McHale and McHale, 'Futures studies', pp. 300-306; McHale and McHale, 'An assessment of futures studies worldwide', pp. 135-145.

[145]Andersson, 'The Great Future Debate and the Struggle for the World', pp. 1411-1430; J. A. Bell, 'James A. Dator: The man who beats the drum for futures studies', *Journal of Futures Studies*, 18 (2013), pp. 105–110.

[146]Ruud van der Helm, 'The future according to Frederik Lodewijk Polak: Finding the roots of contemporary futures studies', *Futures*, 37 (2005), pp. 505–519; A. Curry, 'Images of the future' (2023).

[147]Fred Polak, *The Image of the Future* (Elsevier Scientific Publishing Company, 1955/1973).

[148]UNESCO, 'Futurology', *International Social Science Journal*, XXI (1969); UNESCO, 'What future for futurology?', in *The UNESCO Courier: A Window to the World* (Paris: UNESCO, 1971).

[149]UNESCO, 'What future for futurology?'

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In the course of the 1980s and 1990s, as futures studies shifted emphasis from questions of technology, space, war, and world peace towards indigenous cultures, ecologism, feminism, and design, UNESCO continued to partake in the field's development.[150] On the opposite side of the divide, IOs such as the OECD, NATO, and the Council of Europe remained more closely wedded to the idea of scientific futurology, and thus to notions of probability, causality, and prediction.[151]

Taken together, these historical fragements, dispersed 'bits and pieces'[152] from the historical archive illustrate that the study of world politics and international institutions themselves were deeply intertwined in the complex historical emergence of foresight. Considering this, genealogy is relevant today, since it destabilizes contemporary notions of foresight as a *novel*, fresh, and innovative species of knowledge that can be applied to world affairs, instead uncovering forgotten lines of descent. It illustrates that historically, IOs as political institutions and IR as a discipline were much more closely intertwined with futures studies and foresight than is commonly assumed or remembered. Against this backdrop, the current circulation and cultivation of foresight in IOs can be reassessed and problematized as a rediscovery and rearticulation, rather than a sudden eruption of new truths and insights. Moreover, the claims to novelty and innovation that accompany and authorize foresight as relevant expertise in IOs and elsewhere can be reassessed as closely related to its objectified, and commodified character. Novelty fashions expertise as relevant, useful, and urgent. It convinces IOs and other organizations to invest in foresight, privileging this strand of future-oriented expertise and the professionals who provide it, over others.

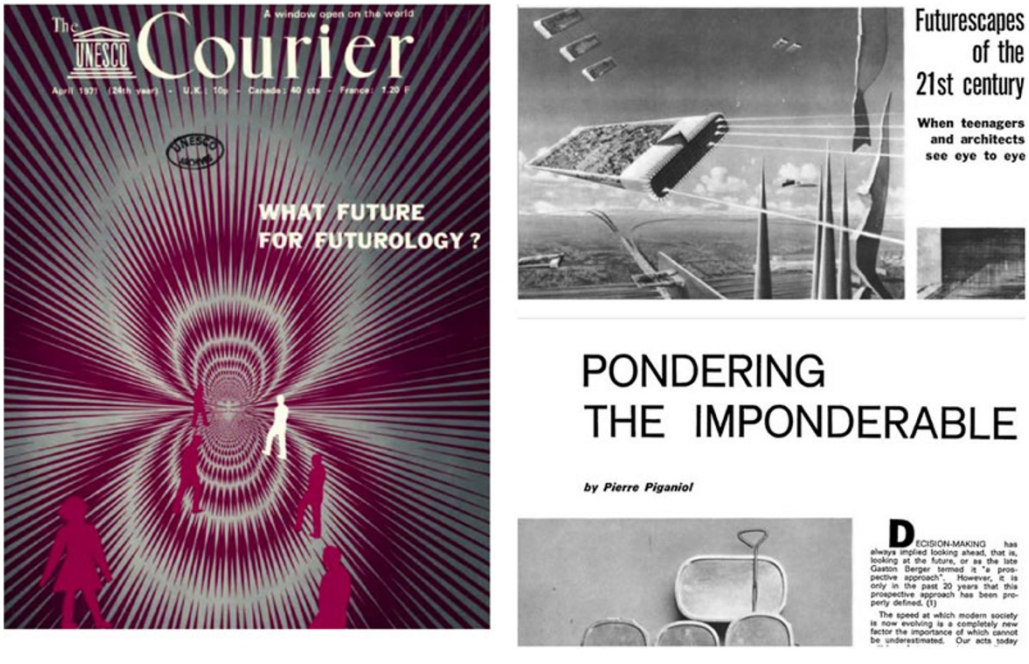

Figure 5. Collage of images from *The UNESCO Courier* with the theme 'What Future of Futurology?'[153]

[150] Eleonora Barbieri Masini, 'The futures of cultures' (UNESCO, 1994); Eleonora Barbieri Masini, 'Women's role in post-industrial democracy', in *The UNESCO Courier: A Window Open on the World, XLV, 11* (1992); Eleonora Barbieri Masini and Johan Galtung, 'Visiones de sociedades deseables' (WFSF CEESTEM, 1978); Eleonora Barbieri Masini and Susan Stratigos (eds), *Women, Households and Change* (United Nations University Press, 1991).

[151] Andersson, *The Future of the World: Futurology*.

[152] Walters, *Governmentality.*

[153] UNESCO, 'What future for futurology?'.

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Concluding discussion

In this article, I have explored speculative foresight as a popular but sparsely researched form of future-oriented expertise in IOs that allows it to complexify received assumptions about the politics of knowledge in international institutions and the nature of future-oriented expertise. In times when diagnoses of deep uncertainty and polycrisis abound, foresight is perceived as a relevant toolkit for political organizations on the world stage as they seek to approach uncertainty, flux, and the unknowability of the future with confidence and competence. Attending to IO's use of foresight and its history, I explored the surprisingly eclectic nature of IO expertise and called attention to the plural ways in which it is authorized. Venturing into the historical archive, I found that – contrary to conventional wisdom – the genealogies of IR, IOs, and foresight were in fact closely entangled in the second half of the 20th century. Moreover, I discussed how core onto-epistemic commitments that mark IO foresight today differ from more well-researched forms of future-oriented expertise and I showed how these commitments emerged historically through the establishment of 'futures studies' as an activist, utopian, and aesthetic counter-project to scientific Cold War futurology. Mobilizing performative accounts of future-oriented practices and Knorr Cetina's work, I proposed to conceptualize foresight as a bundle of epistemic practices that constitute the future as plural and contingent, and allows for IOs to relate to this temporal register despite its assumed radical unknowability. As a scholarly intervention, my aim in this article has thus been to push the literatures on IO expertise and future-oriented practices by exploring how foresight expertise operates in the present and by illuminating selected strands of its complex genealogical web of emergence in 20th century futurisms.

Before I conclude, I would like to offer some brief reflections on promising directions for future research that would go beyond the immediate focus of this short article. First, the performative potential of foresight practices that I discussed above calls for a more thorough ethico-political assessment of the constitutive effects of speculative and creative ways of futuring, its import for political accountability, and its intertwinement with global power asymmetries. How can, or must, we (re)imagine political response-ability if the future is acted upon as something radically unknowable? What experiences, hopes, and fears are made present in foresight practices by IOs and other actors in global politics? Such inquiries could mobilize theorizing on political representation, agency, and voice to interrogate who is (not) positioned to speak, act, and thus to craft futures in, and of, international politics. In a similar vein, future research could study how contemporary IOs and other political actors (re)interpret contingency and pluralism as sources of danger and anxiety in the context of uncertainty and policycrisis, rather than sources of political possibility and renewal. Second, and related, this article has focused on the current renaissance of speculative foresight in policy circles and specifically its take-up in IOs, and it has traced some of its historical beginnings back to activist and aesthetic strands of futurism in the late 1960s and early 1970s. Yet, the broader genealogy of contemporary futurism also includes other lines of descent that deserve further scholarly attention in order to problematize how the future is (re)imagined and brought to bear on the present. For instance, this applies to future-oriented political ideologies that flourish across big technology companies, philanthrocapitalist ventures, and speculative strands of contemporary philosophy that recent research has linked to 20th century eugenics and sought to summarize in the concept of the 'TESCREAL bundle' – an acronym for 'transhumanism, extropianism, singularitarianism, (modern) cosmism, rationalism, effective altruism, and longtermism'.[154] As another example, more research is needed on the present political legacies of futurisms beyond Euromodernity and the West, such as Afrofuturisms, Sinofuturisms, and Indofuturisms, including the strong presence of artistic forms

[154] Timnit Gebru and Émile P. Torres, 'The TESCREAL bundle: Eugenics and the promise of utopia through artificial general intelligence', *First Monday*, 29 (2024).

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of envisioning in these lineages, the (co)evolution of multiple socio-technical futurist imaginaries, and a historical reappraisal of decolonization as a futurist enterprise from the (global) South.

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